

Glossary

Words in **bold** within a definition can be cross-referenced to their own entry.

12-tone music

Works in which each note of the **chromatic scale** is ascribed the same amount of importance, eliminating any concept of **key** or **tonality**. Developed by Arnold Schoenberg and others in the 1920s. See also serialism.

a cappella

Unaccompanied singing by a soloist or a group.

alto

The highest male and lowest female voice; also a term describing an instrument that is lower in **pitch** than a **treble** instrument.

aria

Literally “air” (Italian), a vocal piece, usually for one voice, in an **opera** or **oratorio**, more formally organized than a song. Arias written in the 17th and 18th centuries usually take the form of “da capo arias,” with a three-